

KNOCKING ON GOD'S DOOR

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

The word 'religion' typically evokes a reaction from Marxists which borders on the hostile. The species in Kerala is no exception, though they seemingly have no reservations about the state being marketed in tourist brochures all over the world as 'God's own country'. When it comes to the religious sentiments of people—particularly the majority community—they can be quite insensitive. Last week, their penchant for stoking controversy came to the fore once again when the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government filed an affidavit in the Supreme Court, in favour of a PIL requesting that the traditional ban on the entry of women of menstrual age into the famous Sabarimala temple in Kerala's hilly Western Ghats be lifted.

Although the Government has since said that it is not going to initiate any steps immediately to revoke the ban, temple priests, various devotee organisations and political parties like BJP have opposed the move. With annual revenues exceeding Rs 100 crore during the three festive months from November to January—the only time of the year when the temple remains open—Sabarimala is the richest temple in the state and provides sustenance to the 2,000-plus temples in Kerala.

In a 15-page affidavit, the Government has said that it cannot take any stand that is against the Indian Constitution which guarantees equal religious rights to all those who practise and preach the same religion. "We have to protect the fundamental rights guaranteed by the Constitution to all citizens and cannot discriminate on the basis of caste, creed, class or gender," says G. Sudhakaran, minister for temple affairs, who has been campaigning for revoking the traditional ban on the entry of women as well as non-Hindus into the Sabarimala and temples at Guruvayur. The affidavit adds that as the ban on women was upheld by the high court in 1991, the Government could not



MALE BASTION: Men line up for darshan at the Sabarimala temple

render any independent direction to alter the prevailing custom. It has requested the apex court to appoint a commission of scholars and social reformers to submit their suggestions on this issue before a decision is taken.

The Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB)—which manages the administration of the temples across the state—constituted by the previous United Democratic Front (UDF) government has been in favour of the ban. However, TDB President C.K. Gupthan, appointed by the present Government, says the board

would support the Government's position. "It is barbaric to continue with discrimination based on gender," says Gupthan, who is also the son-in-law of the late Marxist patriarch E.M.S. Namboothiripad. Many women's groups have welcomed the entry of one and all into the temple. "It is the fundamental right of a woman to visit any temple she wants to," says K. Ajitha, a former Naxalite, who now heads Anveshi, a women's rights group.

The Government has suggested a separate and exclusive season for women devotees to dispel fears about possible law and order problems in case